Ron Hensley

ronkhensley@gmail.com

AAS in AI Software Engineering

PSYC100

False memories

Today
Welcome to your next lesson: False memories.

I'm preparing your personalized lesson based on what you've already learned, what's coming next, and the best way to help you grow.

Step by step, you’re moving forward.

Let’s start with this short video: “Are all of your memories real?” 🤖

Watch it first, then we’ll connect it to real experiments on false memories.

When you’re done, tell me in a sentence or two:

What surprised you most from the video?

what surprised me most was people ho supported lefalization in 73, thats a strong belief and at the time against the grain of society, thn remembered hot suporting in 9 years later , very surprising

Yeah, that part is wild 😮

That example is a perfect doorway into today’s idea: memory isn’t a video recorder. Even a strong, identity-level belief (like a political stance) can be remembered differently later, just because of how questions are asked and how our mind fills in gaps.

I want to connect this to a classic experiment with a simple scene: a car accident 🚗💥

Imagine you watch a short video where one car hits another at an intersection.

Then I ask you:

“About how fast were the cars going when they hit each other?”

Just follow your gut:

If you had to give a number, what speed (mph) would you guess?

45

Nice, 45 mph is a very natural kind of answer 👍

Now here’s the key twist researchers tested:

They showed the same car crash video to different groups, but changed one word in the question:

“How fast were the cars going when they contacted each other?”
“How fast were the cars going when they hit each other?”
“How fast were the cars going when they smashed into each other?”

People who heard “smashed” gave higher speed estimates than people who heard “hit” or “contacted.”

Same video. Different verb. Different memory.

This is our first big idea: a leading word can change how we remember the event.

We call this the misinformation effect.

Make sense so far, Ron?

If yes, I’ll show you how this same wording even made people remember broken glass that never existed.

Yes, that makes sense

Great ☑

Let’s go one small step deeper with the same study.

After the crash video, a week later the researchers brought people back and asked:

“Did you see any broken glass?”

Important detail:

There was no broken glass in the film. None. 😳

But:

People who first got the word “smashed” were more likely to say yes, they saw broken glass.
People who got the word “hit” were less likely to “remember” broken glass.

So just hearing “smashed” first helped create a false memory of glass.

👉 This shows memory is reconstructive: each time we remember, we rebuild the story using:

the original event
plus later words, questions, and suggestions

Quick check for you:

If a police officer asks a witness, “How fast was the car going when it smashed into the other one?”, what’s the danger of using that word?

Answer in your own words, 1–2 sentences.

it makes the crash sound big and explsivethus perhaps tainting the witness memoryy of the incident

Exactly 💯

Using a word like “smashed” makes the crash sound more violent, so the witness may:

overestimate speed, and
even “remember” details (like broken glass) that weren’t there

That’s the misinformation effect in action: later wording changes the memory.

Want to try a quick 1-question check on this idea of false memories and wording, or go straight into how this connects to eyewitness testimony in court?

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Perfect, let’s connect this to eyewitness testimony ⚖️

Step by step:

In real life, a witness sees a crime or accident.
Later, a police officer, lawyer, or judge asks questions.
If those questions use strong, leading words (“smashed,” “slammed,” “crashed violently”), they can change how the witness remembers the event.

So in court:

A lawyer who says, “When the car smashed into the victim…” might push the jury and witness to picture a faster, more violent crash than really happened.
That can affect guilt, sentence length, and damages.
Quick gut check:

If you were training new police officers, what’s one simple rule you’d give them about how to word questions for witnesses? (Just one short sentence.)

do not describe the incident in you rown words at all just ask them point blank to describe their answer

That’s an excellent rule of thumb 👌

You’re basically saying:

Don’t feed the witness any description. Let them choose the words.

That’s exactly what psychologists recommend: use neutral, open questions like “Can you describe what you saw?” instead of “When the car smashed into the other one…”

Now I want to zoom out and name the big idea you’ve already been using:

Reconstructive memory = when we remember, we don’t “play back a video”; we rebuild the event using the original scene + later information (like wording, suggestions, conversations).

Loftus & Palmer’s crash study is famous because it shows this reconstruction in a very clear, measurable way.

Does this definition of reconstructive memory line up with how you’re thinking about it, or is any part fuzzy?

That makes sense

Nice 👍

You’ve got the core idea. Now let’s connect it directly to the Loftus & Palmer study so you can explain it cleanly if asked on a test.

Here’s the chain, step by step:

People see a car crash (original event).
They get a question with a verb like “hit” or “smashed” (new information added later).
Their memory changes:
speed estimates shift
some even “remember” broken glass that wasn’t there
So their later “memory” = event + suggestive wording.

That’s reconstructive memory in action.

I want to check this in your own words, but keep it simple:

In 2–3 short sentences, how would you explain to a friend how the Loftus & Palmer crash study shows that memory is reconstructive?

the study showed how using descriptve words when asking a witnes questions can alter their perceptions. telling them desccribe when cars hit vs when cars smashed causes them to remember a faster accident then if just said hit. It also caused memory of the indicent to alter in the future to coincide with the suggestive info given

Beautifully put, Ron 🌟

You hit all the key parts:

You noted that wording (“hit” vs “smashed”) changes perception of speed
You saw that this alters later memories, not just the first estimate
You linked it to suggestive information shaping recall over time

That’s exactly what we mean by memory is reconstructive.

Next, I’d like to have you do a small, practical task:

I’ll show you a bad eyewitness question, and you’ll rewrite it to avoid causing false memories.

Ready for that?

I'm ready

Awesome 👌

Here’s a bad eyewitness question:

“When the red truck smashed into the small blue car and sent glass flying everywhere, how scared were you?”

Problems:

“smashed into” = suggests a very violent crash
“sent glass flying everywhere” = assumes there was flying glass
It feeds details into the witness’s memory

Your turn:

Rewrite that question so it’s neutral and doesn’t add any new details. Just type your new version as one sentence.

Please tel me in your own words what you witnessed and how it made you feel

That rewrite is excellent, Ron 👀

You removed:

the verb “smashed”
the assumption about glass flying everywhere

And you:

let the witness use their own words
separated what they saw from how they felt, which is very clear

This is exactly the kind of wording that reduces false memories.

At this point, you can:

Go deeper (e.g., more practice with neutral vs leading questions), or
Wrap this lesson and move on to the next topic.

What would you prefer right now: a bit more practice, or move on?

I'm ready to move on

Nice work, Ron 🎯

Here’s what you’ve just mastered:

You can explain that memory is reconstructive – it’s not a video replay, it’s a story we rebuild each time.
You understand the Loftus & Palmer (1974) crash study: how verbs like “hit” vs “smashed” changed:
speed estimates
later false memories (like broken glass that never existed)
You can spot and rewrite leading questions into neutral ones to reduce false memories in eyewitness testimony.
This is powerful stuff for real life: it means you’ll be more careful about how you ask questions, and more skeptical about how “certain” memories—yours and others’—really are.

When you’re ready, you can hit Next Lesson in Learn and we’ll keep building on this.
If anything about false memories nags at you later, just ask and we’ll unpack it.